

THE TALE OF TWO CAPTAINS

The concept of "split captaincy" has been tried out intermittently in Australia, England and Sri Lanka, and more often than not, abandoned. It began when Australia's stalwart Mark Taylor shared the captaincy with Steve Waugh, who led the Australian odi team until Taylor's retirement in 1999. England tried out split captaincy first between Mike Atherton (Tests) and Adam Hobbins (odis) and more recently, with Nasser Hussain (Tests) and Michael Vaughan (odis.) Hussain wrote later that the decision to split the captaincy "took a little of the gloss off of what was always a special thing in my heart... it had changed." Sri Lanka, too, tried out Hashan Tillekaratne for Tests and Marvan Attapattu for odis in 2003. Split captaincies usually have short shelf-lives. The longest tenure of a double-header leadership lasted 23 months, between Ricky Ponting (right) and Steve Waugh (top right) as separate captains before Waugh's retirement in 2004.

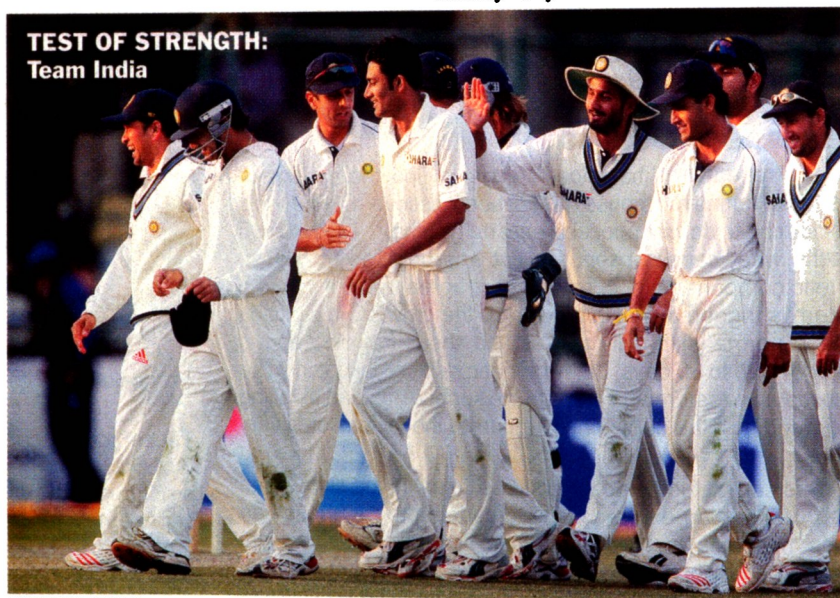


Anil been in the odi team." From within the side, there is equal assent. A player says, "Eventually, whoever the captain is, the team has to perform and play together. We've got to be mature and understand that that's what it's all about."

The dynamics within a cricket team, especially one as diverse as India, can be downright peculiar. Captaincy, says one veteran, makes the most difference to the younger, unsettled players in the team rather than the older pros who know what they must do. So when Kumble walks out on to Delhi's Ferozshah Kotla to begin his Test captaincy, his biggest task as captain will not be to manage the egos of the four captains under his orders, but to bring the more unsure members of the flock on par with the older men.

"The real test of captaincy in India is how quickly you can turn talented youngsters into big-game performers," an insider says. Cricket leadership can often elicit judgements based on lights, mirrors and tricks of memory. In itself, though, it remains the most pitiless of judges. It served to seal the whimsical Sourav Ganguly's place in posterity. Equally unexpectedly, it corroded Rahul Dravid's cast-iron influence within the team. What could it do to Kumble, this undemonstrative but indefatigable competitor?

Bedi is optimistic, "Anil has defied everybody and all norms throughout



AP PHOTO/GURINDER OSAN

his career. Taking up the job might just give him a fresh challenge now."

Kumble has led infrequently in first-class cricket but says he likes it because it means complete absorption in the game. His Karnataka teammates have seen it first-hand. Keeper Thilak Naidu says, "Anil captains like he bowls, he's at the opposition the whole time." Sujith Somasunder, former Karnataka skipper and a batsman himself, recalls a remarkably even-handed leader, able to distance personal equations from cricketing decisions. "As a captain, I know how difficult that can be, but Anil could be very objective."

Even in the golden glow that casts a halo around the heads of all new

India captains, Kumble retains his hold on reality. "I know there's a big difference between leading Karnataka and leading India." He has seen cricketers with Tendulkar's gifts and Dravid's equanimity struggle with it.

Captaining India is a job that Wright says is "more in the spotlight than any other in world cricket". It is an undiscerning and unrelenting spotlight. Along with tactical acumen, Indian captains must have thick skins or learn to grow them. "Some people enjoy it more than others," says Pataudi, "but after a while, it becomes more of a headache and people tend to shy away from it."

Former India wicketkeeper Saba Karim believes Dravid and Tendulkar kept away from it mainly due to the way the current selection committee is being run. He says, "There seems to be hardly any communication or trust

between selectors and the captain. There needs to be decorum and confidentiality. I hope selectors give that respect to Anil." The Indian selectors could benefit from this temporary period of goodwill by charting out a plan for a phased change of captains in consultation with Kumble.

Somasunder once received a piece of advice from this titan in his dressing room. Every time you step on to the field, he was told, play like it's your last chance. No next session, next innings, next match. There is only now.

Kumble knows fully well that his will be a brief holdover of authority until a younger man takes over. For him, in every sense, there is only now. ■